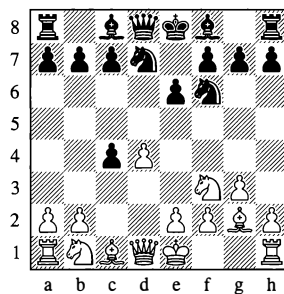


Chapter 5

Catalan 4...dxc4



5...♘bd7

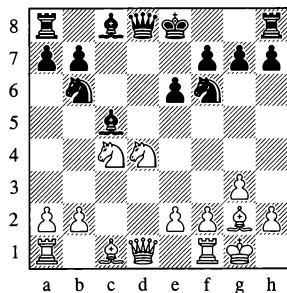
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 ♘bd7

6.0-0

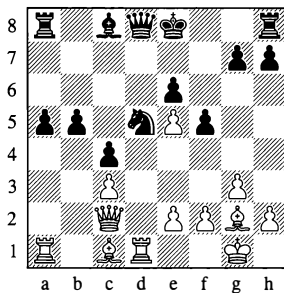
A) 6...c5	64
B) 6...c6	65
C) 6...a6	66
D) 6...♗b8	67
E) 6...♙e7	68
F) 6...♘b6 7.♘bd2 c5 8.♘xc4 ♘xc4 9.♙a4† ♙d7 10.♙xc4	69
F1) 10...♙b6	70
F2) 10...♗c8	71
F3) 10...b5	71

A) after 9...♘b6



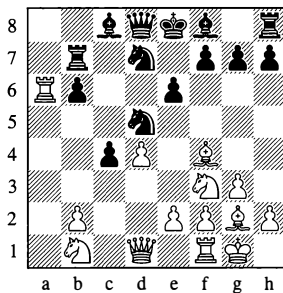
10.♙e3!N

B) note to 8...♘b6



15.e4!N

C) after 11...♘d5

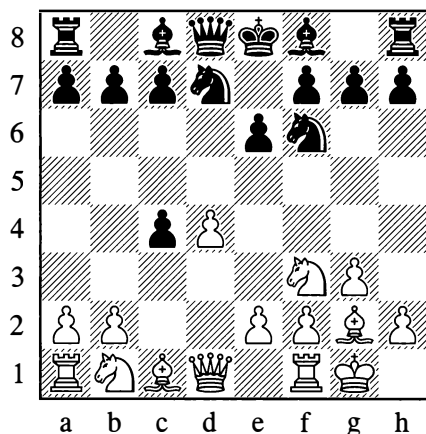


12.♙d2!?N

1.d4 ♖f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♗f3 dxc4 5.♙g2 ♖bd7

A developing move, but too passive to equalize.

6.0–0

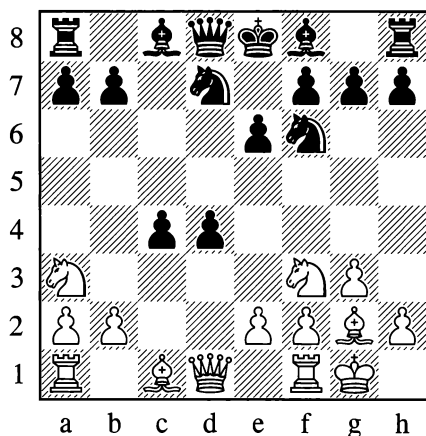


Black has a wide choice of possibilities:
A) 6...c5, B) 6...c6, C) 6...a6, D) 6...♜b8,
E) 6...♙e7 and the main line F) 6...♗b6.

These moves cover a huge range of different motifs such as attacking White's centre, simple development or desperately hanging on to the c4-pawn. This variety makes it sensible to explain the themes as they arise in the analysis rather than attempt a strategic overview now.

A) 6...c5 7.♗a3 cxd4

7...♗b6 8.♗xc4 will be covered in line F.



8.♗xc4

The position is definitely favourable for White, since the black knight is misplaced on d7.

8...♙c5

Other moves are less promising for Black:

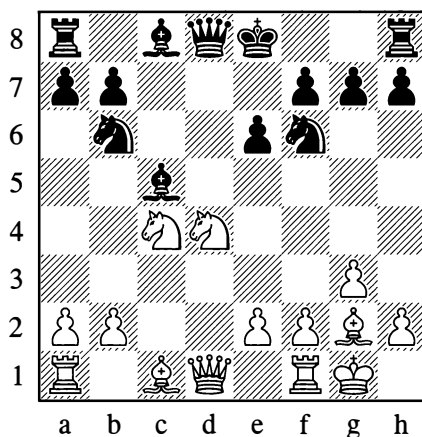
8...♙e7 9.♗xd4 0–0 10.♗b5! ♗c5 11.♗bd6+ and White was clearly better in Timoschenko – Kholmov, USSR 1982.

8...♗b6 9.♗ce5! ♙e7 10.♗xd4 0–0 11.♗b5! and White had a lot of pressure in Fernandez – Lopez Martin, email 2011.

9.♗xd4 ♗b6

Another possibility is 9...0–0 10.♗b3 ♙e7 11.♙f4 ♗b6 12.♜xd8 ♙xd8, and now in the game Mchedlishvili – T.A. Petrosian, Yerevan 2004, White could have capitalized on his initiative by means of: 13.♜fc1N ♗fd5 14.♙d6 ♙e8 15.♗ca5 With a pleasant advantage.

After the text I believe White can improve on existing theory with a strong novelty.



10.♙e3!N

Black has a tricky idea of meeting 10.♗xb6 ♙xb6 11.♗b5 with a nice tactical shot: 11...♙xf2! 12.♜xf2 ♜b6† 13.♗d4 e5 Black

was more or less fine in Tal – Danov, Moscow 1972.

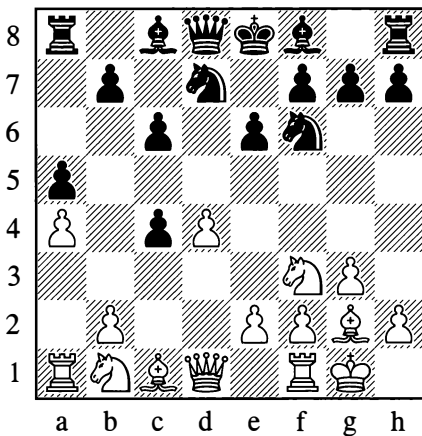
10...0-0 11.♖b5 ♕xe3 12.♖xe3±

White has lasting pressure.

B) 6...c6 7.a4 a5

7...♕d6?! 8.♖bd2 0-0 9.♖xc4 ♕c7 is hardly a recommendable idea, although it has been played several times. 10.a5! ♖b8 11.♗c2N± White is much better.

7...♕e7 8.♖bd2 (This is more accurate than the previously recommended 8.♗c2, as after 8...b6 9.♗xc4 ♕b7 Black had a decent game in Ozturk – Adamowicz, Pardubice 2009.) 8...0-0 9.a5! (There is nothing wrong with 9.♖xc4, but the text is more ambitious, as White doesn't want to allow ...♖b6.) 9...b5 10.axb6 ♖xb6 11.♖e5 ♗c7 12.♖dxc4 ♖xc4 13.♖xc4 ♖d5 14.♕d2± White was clearly better in Mester – Blasko, Eger 1997.



8.♗c2 ♖b6

Trying to hold on to the pawn is too dangerous for Black:

8...b5 9.♖e5! ♖xe5 10.dxe5 ♖d5 11.axb5 cxb5 12.♖c3 ♕b4

Other moves don't offer Black relief either:

a) 12...♖b4?! 13.♗d2 ♗xd2 14.♕xd2 ♖b8

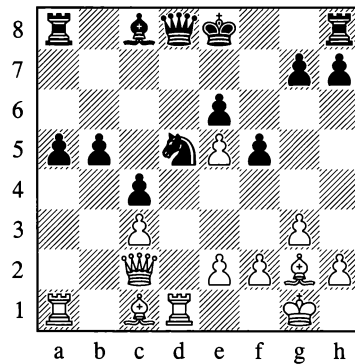
15.♖xa5 ♕d7 16.♖fa1 ♕e7 17.♖a7± and Black is in serious trouble.

b) 12...♗d7 13.♖d1 ♕b7 14.e4 ♖b4 15.♖xd7 ♖xc2 16.♖xb7 ♖xa1 17.♖xb5 leads to a clear advantage for White.

c) 12...♕c5 13.♖xb5 ♕a6 14.♕g5! f6 (14...♗xg5 loses to 15.♕xd5 exd5 16.♖c7+ ♖d7 17.♖xa8 ♖xa8 18.♖xa5 as the threat of 19.♗a4 decides the game.) 15.exf6 gxf6 16.♕xd5 exd5 17.♕xf6! ♗xf6 18.♖c7+ ♖d7 19.♖xa8 ♖xa8 20.♖xa5+– White is winning.

13.♖d1 ♕xc3 14.bxc3 f5

All this occurred in Guzy – Salvatore, email 2006, and now White should have played:

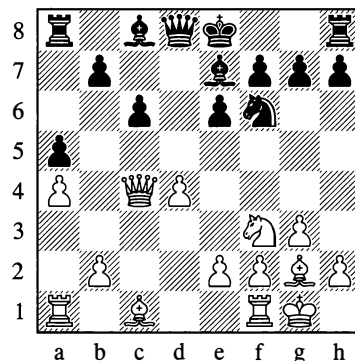


15.e4!N fxe4 16.♕xe4 ♕b7 17.♕a3

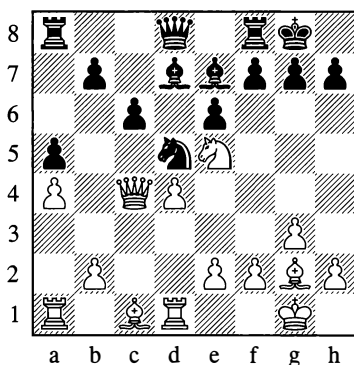
White has a powerful initiative for his pawn.

9.♖bd2 ♖fd5

The character of the game would not be changed by: 9...♕e7 10.♖xc4 ♖xc4 (10...♖bd5 happened in Arkhipov – Shovunov, Orel 1997, when White could have improved with: 11.♖fe5N 0-0 12.♕d2±) 11.♗xc4



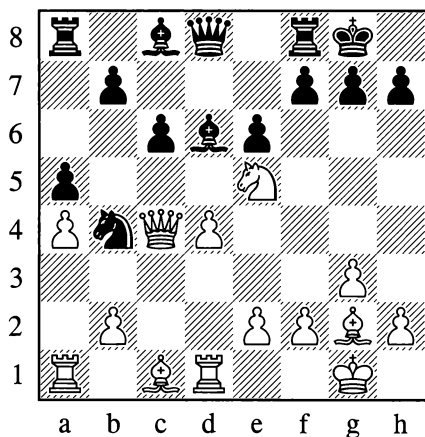
11...0-0 (11...♖b6 12.♗e5 0-0 13.e4 ♖b4 14.♙e3 ♗d7 15.♖xb4 ♙xb4 was Timman – Kuijf, Amsterdam 1996, and now best is 16.♗c4!N) 12.♗e5 (12.♞d1 ♖d5 13.♗e5 ♖xc4 14.♗xc4±) 12...♗d5 13.♞d1 ♙d7 This was Stajcic – Baburin, Budapest 1992, and now I like:



14.♙d2N ♙e8 15.♗d3±

10.♗xc4 ♗b4 11.♖b3 ♗xc4 12.♖xc4 ♙e7 13.♞d1 0-0 14.♗e5 ♙d6

This was Maksimovic – Laketic, Vrnjacka Banja 2010, and here my preference is for:



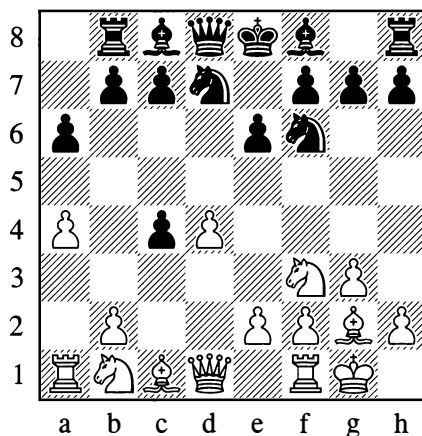
15.♙d2N ♖e7 16.♙c3±

White retains a small but long-term advantage.

C) 6...a6 7.a4 ♖b8

A logical follow-up to Black's previous play.

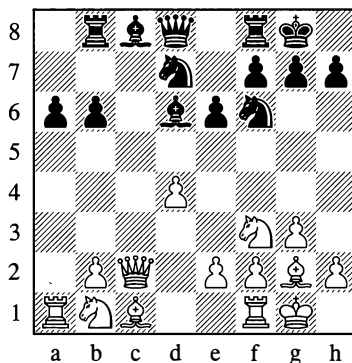
I would also like to mention 7...c5 8.♗bd2 cxd4 9.♗xc4, when White has similar pressure to that shown in variation A. One good example is: 9...♗b6 10.♗ce5 ♙c5 11.♖c2 ♙d6?! 12.♞d1 ♖c7 13.♖xc7 ♙xc7 14.♞xd4± White was clearly better in Gonzalez Garcia – Thompson, Barcelona 2011.



8.a5 b5

8...♙d6 9.♗bd2 b5 10.axb6 ♗xb6 11.e4 ♙b4 12.♗e5 ♙b7 13.♗dxc4 0-0 14.♖d3 saw White regain his pawn and maintain a solid positional edge in Meins – Proehl, Germany 1998.

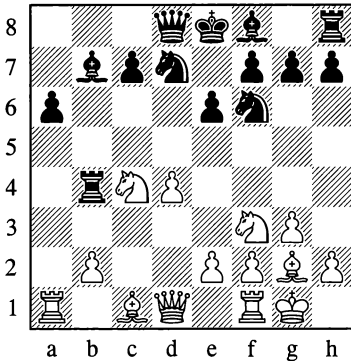
8...♙b4 9.♖c2 0-0 10.♖xc4 ♙d6 11.♖c2 b5 12.axb6 cxb6



13.e4 was agreed drawn at this point in Jaracz – Gaponenko, Schwaebisch Gmuend 2005. However, White is better after the following logical line: 13...♞c7 14.♞e2 e5 15.♟c3 ♟b7 16.♟g5

9.axb6 cxb6

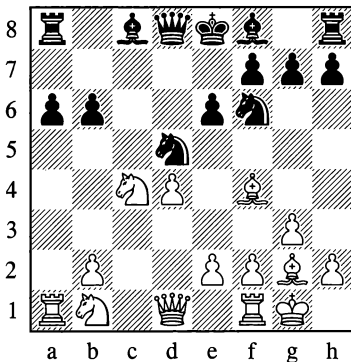
9...♞xb6 10.♟bd2 ♟b7 11.♟xc4 ♞b4 occurred in Rahman – Boshku, Dresden (ol) 2008, and now I like:



12.b3N (threatening 13.♟a3) 12...♞b5 13.♞c2 ♟b4 14.♟e1! ♟xg2 15.♟xg2 0–0 16.♟d3 ♞a8† 17.f3± With a clear positional advantage for White.

10.♟f4 ♞b7

10...♞a8 11.♟fd2 (11.♟e5 ♟d5 12.♟xc4 is the same) 11...♟d5 12.♟xc4 ♟7f6 does not look like much fun for Black.

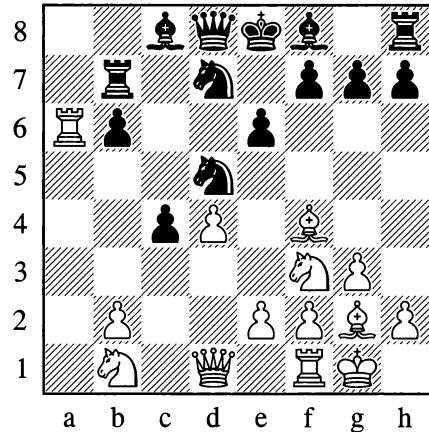


In Evdokimov – Burkanov, Ufa 2004, White could have continued 13.♟g5N with

the idea 13...♟b4? 14.e4 ♟e7 15.e5 ♟fd5 16.♟c3 0–0 17.♟a2!. White has a winning advantage.

11.♞xa6 ♟d5

This happened in Tukmakov – Rodriguez Vargas, New York 1988, and now my choice is:



12.♟d2!?N ♟e7 13.♞a1 0–0 14.b3! b5

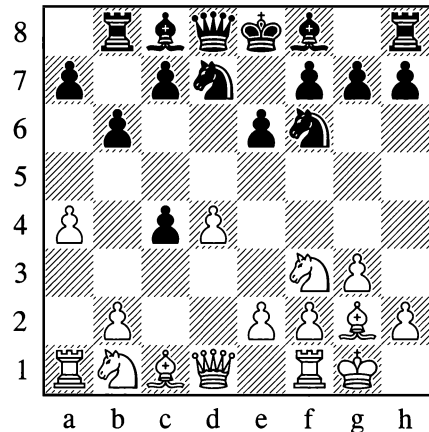
14...cxb3 15.♞xb3 b5 16.♟a5 ♞e8 17.♞c1 b4 18.e4 ♟5f6 19.♟bd2 is also clearly better for White.

15.bxc4 bxc4 16.♟a5 ♞e8 17.♟bd2±

Black is losing the c-pawn.

D) 6...♞b8 7.a4 b6

7...a6 leads back to variation C.



8. ♖fd2!

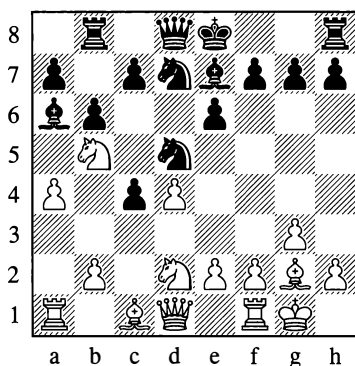
It is important to put the correct knight on this square!

8... ♗b7

Black has tried other moves as well:

8...e5 9. ♖xc4 exd4 10. ♖xd4 ♗c5 11. ♖d3 0-0 12. ♖c3 ♗b7 13. ♗xb7 ♖xb7 14. ♖f3 ♖a8 15. ♗f4 gave White a solid edge in the well-known encounter Kasparov – Korchnoi, London (9) 1983.

After 8... ♗a6 9. ♖c3! White's knight is heading for the b5-square, showing the reason for playing the other knight to d2. 9... ♗e7 10. ♖b5 ♖d5 was Tashkov – Spasov, Bulgaria 1995, and now a simple and efficient improvement is:



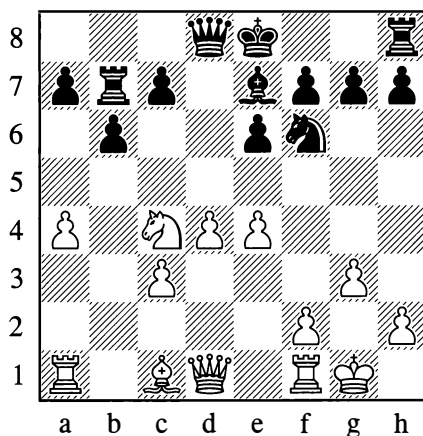
11.e4N ♖b4 12. ♖xc4 0-0 13. ♗f4 White has a substantial advantage.

9. ♗xb7 ♖xb7 10. ♖xc4 ♗e7

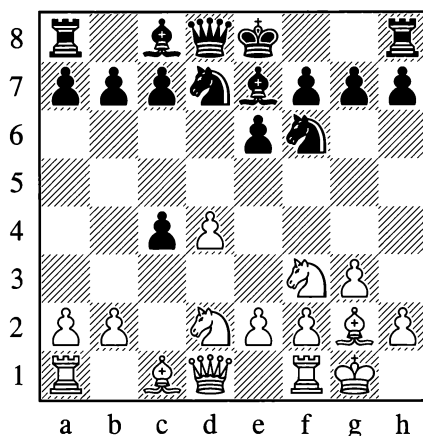
Another Black try is 10... ♗b4 11. ♖b3 a5 12. ♖f3 ♖c8 13. ♖c3 0-0 as played in Khalifman – Portisch, Bazna 2008. White could obtain a solid advantage with: 14. ♖b5N!±

11. ♖c3 ♖d5 12.e4 ♖xc3 13.bxc3 ♖f6

We have been following Bandza – Klovans, Lvov 1984. White would retain a pleasant edge with:

**14. ♖f3N 0-0 15. ♗d1±****E) 6... ♗e7 7. ♖bd2**

I was somewhat surprised by the number of previous games to have reached this position.

**7... ♖b6**

7...0-0 8. ♖xc4 c5 leaves White with a comfortable edge, for example: 9.b3 ♖b6 10. ♖ce5 ♖bd5 11. ♗b2 Shefer – Kiripov, Moscow 2010.

Of course it is important to investigate Black's attempt to hold on to his extra pawn:

7...b5 8.a4 c6 9.axb5 cxb5 10. ♖e5 ♖xe5

10... ♖d5 11. ♖c6 ♖b6 12. ♖xe7 ♖xe7 cannot be good for Black, as in Pleshkov – Gorniy,

St Petersburg 2007. White could have seized a serious initiative by means of 13.b3N c3 14.♟c4 bxc4 15.bxc4 with a clear plus.

11.♟xa8 ♖xd4 12.♟f3 ♟xf3† 13.♟xf3 ♖b6

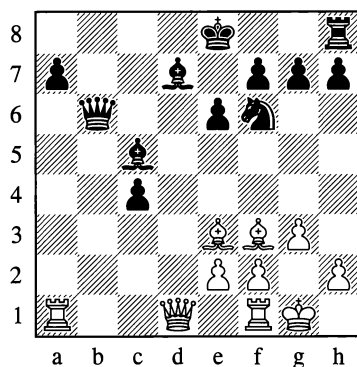
White's next move is important, as otherwise Black would be absolutely fine:

14.b3! ♟d7

14...c3 doesn't work in view of 15.♟e3 ♟c5 16.♟xc5 ♖xc5 17.b4! ♖b6 18.♖d3 with a large advantage.

14...0-0 15.bxc4 bxc4 16.♟e3 ♟c5 17.♟xc5 ♖xc5 18.♖a4± and it looks like Black is going to lose both his queenside pawns. White went on to win in Ni Hua – Jakubowski, Oropesa del Mar 1999.

15.bxc4 bxc4 16.♟e3 ♟c5



17.♖a6!!

A beautiful exchange sacrifice, which changes the course of the game.

17...♖xa6 18.♟xc5

It's hard for Black to solve the problem of his king, and White unsurprisingly crashed through in the following game:

18...e5 19.♖d2 e4 20.♖b1 ♖e6 21.♖b8† ♟c8 22.♖a5 ♖d7 23.♟b4!

Black resigned in Dimitrov – Spasov, email 2010.

8.♖c2 0-0 9.♟xc4 ♟xc4 10.♖xc4 c6 11.♖c2 ♖b6 12.♟d2 ♟d7 13.♖fc1 ♖ac8 14.b4±

White had a dream position in Smejkal – Unzicker, Amsterdam 1980.

F) 6...♟b6

This logical follow-up is Black's main continuation.

7.♟bd2 c5

7...♟e7 transposes to variation E on the previous page.

7...♟d7

White should react aggressively:

8.a4! ♟c6

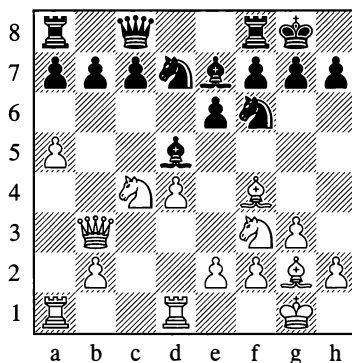
In the event of 8...a5 9.♟e5 ♟fd5 10.♟dxc4 ♟xc4 11.♟xc4 ♟e7 12.♟d2 b6 13.e4 ♟b4 we can play ambitiously and improve on Lilienthal – Kan, Leningrad 1947: 14.e5N ♖c8 15.♖g4 With a pleasant initiative.

9.a5 ♟bd7 10.♟xc4 ♟e7 11.♖b3 0-0 12.♖d1 ♖c8

More natural would be 12...♟d5, but even here after 13.♟fe5 c5 14.♟e3± White retains definite pressure.

13.♟f4 ♟d5

This occurred in Kiss – P. Horvath, Aggtelek 1997. White could have increased his advantage by means of:

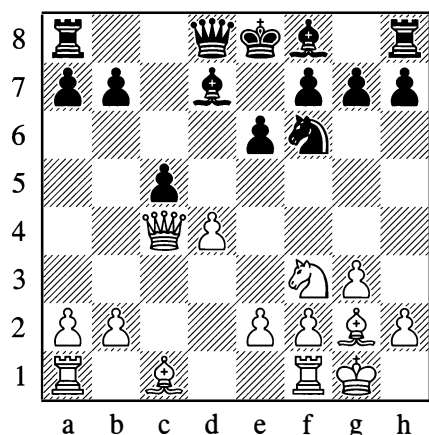


14.♟fe5N ♟xg2 15.♖xg2 ♟d5 16.♟d2 c5 17.♖ac1

8.♟xc4 ♟xc4

8...cxd4 is examined in the 6...c5 line.

9.♖a4† ♟d7 10.♖xc4



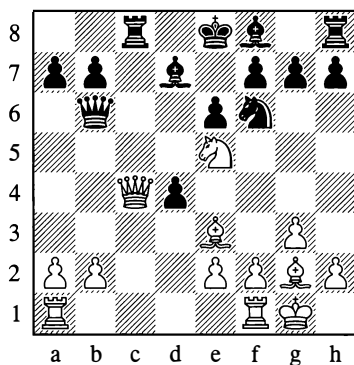
At this point Black can choose between F1) 10...♖b6, F2) 10...♞c8 and F3) 10...b5.

F1) 10...♖b6 11.♠e3! ♜d5

11...♞c8 12.♜e5

12.♞fc1!? also looks powerful.

12...cxd4



13.♠xd4! ♠c5

13...♞xc4 leads to a losing endgame for Black after 14.♠xb6 ♞b4 15.♠xa7 ♞xb2 16.♞fb1.

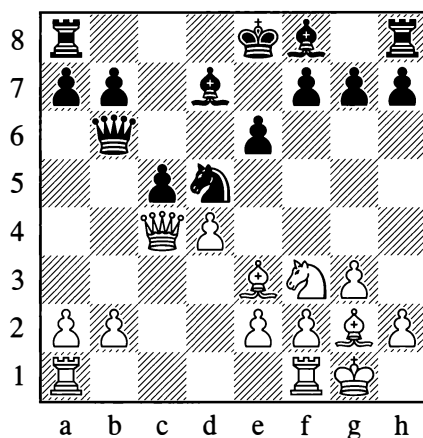
14.♜xd7 ♜xd7

14...♞xd7 15.♞a4† ♞e7 16.♠c3± leaves White with a comfortable advantage thanks to his bishop pair.

15.b4! ♞xb4 16.♞xb4 ♠xb4 17.♠xb7 ♞c7 18.♞fc1±

The arising endgame is clearly better for

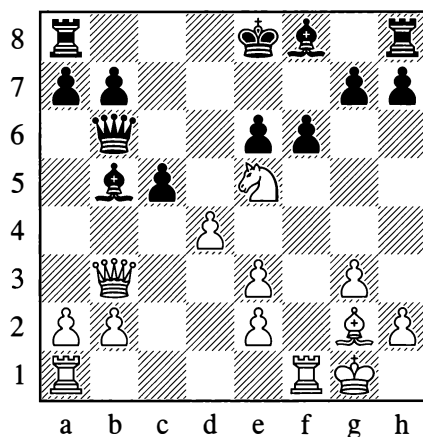
White, who went on to win in Radashkovich – Razuvaev, USSR 1971.



12.♜e5 ♜xe3

Just bad is 12...♠b5, as in Carlhammar – L. Schneider, Stockholm 1987. After 13.dxc5!N ♜xe3 14.♞f4! ♞c7 15.fxe3 f6 16.♜d3 ♞xf4 17.♜xf4 ♠xc5 18.♜xe6 ♠xe3† 19.♞h1 White's material advantage should decide.

13.fxe3 ♠b5 14.♞b3 f6



15.♜c4N

All four games here went 15.♠c6†, which looks extremely attractive. However, I found things to be less clear after 15...♠xc6 16.♞xe6† ♞d8!N (16...♠e7 17.♞f7† ♞d8 18.♞ad1 does indeed lead to a powerful attack for White).

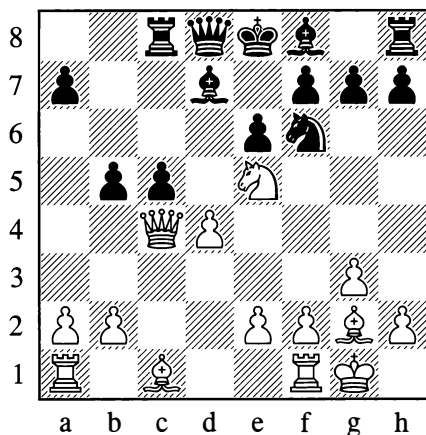
15...♙xc4 16.♖xc4

Despite the presence of opposite-coloured bishops, White has a significant initiative. For example:

**16...♙e7 17.♙h3 f5 18.dxc5 ♙xc5 19.♙xf5!
♙xe3† 20.♖g2±**

F2) 10...♖c8 11.♗e5 b5

Even worse is 11...cxd4 12.♖xd4 ♙c5 13.♖d3 ♖b6 14.♗xd7 ♗xd7 15.♖e4 0–0 16.♖xb7± when White was just a pawn up in Vukic – Cvetkovic, Umag 1972.

**12.♖d3 c4**

12...♙d6 13.♙g5 c4

13...0–0 14.♖fd1 c4 15.♖c2 ♙e7 16.a4± is much better for White.

14.♖c2 ♖c7

I also checked the following line: 14...0–0 15.a4 bxa4 16.♙xf6 gxf6 17.♗xd7 ♖xd7 18.♖xa4 c3 19.bxc3 ♖xc3 20.♖xa7 ♖xc2 21.♖xd7± It looks like White should prevail – by slowly building towards the d4-d5 break.

**15.♙xf6 gxf6 16.♗xd7 ♖xd7 17.d5! 0–0
18.♖ad1 e5?**

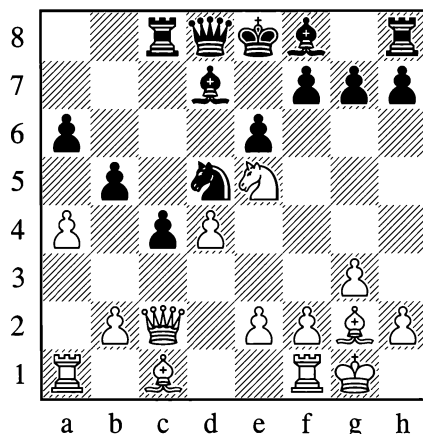
Even after the best 18...♖e7 19.♖d4 ♙e5 20.♖h4 f5 21.e4 White has a dangerous initiative on the kingside.

19.♙e4

White's advantage was undisputed in Levitt – Steckner, Hamburg 1982.

13.♖c2

White is clearly better here, with a critical line being as follows:

13...♗d5 14.a4 a6**15.e4N**

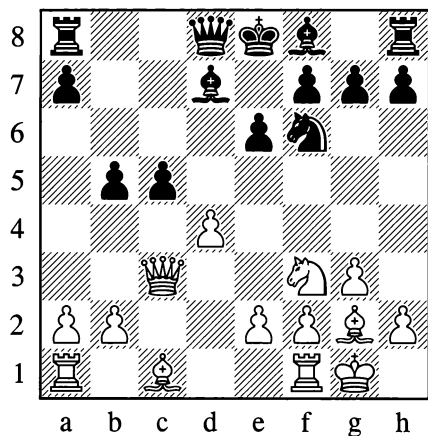
As recommended by Alburt in *Chess Informant* 39. 15.axb5 ♙xb5 16.♙d2 ♙d6 was less convincing in Alburt – Browne, Taxco 1985.

15...♗b4 16.♖c3 ♙e7 17.d5 0–0 18.axb5

White has a pleasant advantage after either 18...axb5 19.♙e3± or 18...♙xb5 19.dxe6 fxe6 20.♙h3 ♖d6 21.♙f4±.

F3) 10...b5 11.♖c3!

This uncommon move is the most attractive here. The main advantage is that the d-pawn is now protected, so White is ready to play ♗e5 on the very next move.

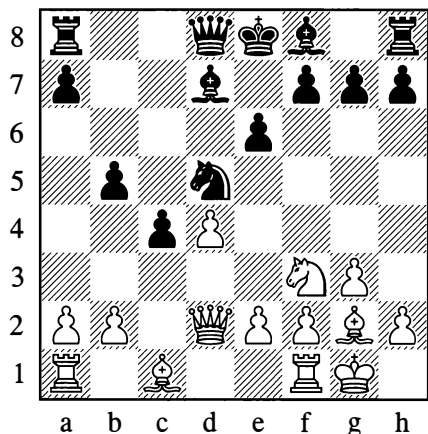


11...♟d5 12.♖d2!

Another strange-looking square, but White intends to follow up with 13.e4 and wants to avoid ...♟b4 coming with tempo.

12...c4

Here I found an improvement over an existing game:



13.e4N

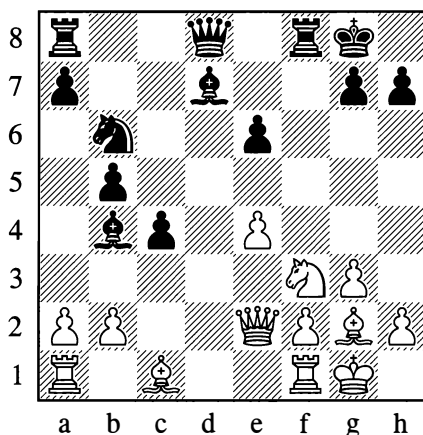
The only game in which 11.♙c3 occurred continued 13.♟e5 ♟b4 14.♙c2, Romanov – Likhachev, corr. 2013. Black should have played 14...0-0N 15.a3 ♟e7 when his position looks satisfactory.

13...♟b4

13...♟b4 14.d5↑ leads to a serious initiative for White.

14.♙e2 ♟b6 15.d5 0-0 16.dxe6 fxe6

After 16...♟xe6 17.♟g5 ♙e8 18.♟e3 White's chances are better.



17.♟f4

White's position is definitely more promising, although Black retains some chances of his own.

Conclusion

In *GM 1* I stated that Black was simply worse in this line. Not much has changed in that respect, but I have added some new lines of analysis to cover relevant games played in the interim. Variation F in particular should be studied carefully, as Black's play should not be underestimated. However, I am satisfied that my main line offers White excellent prospects.